



How to ask a client for a deposit: 12 emails to copy

Last checked 5 October 2026. Fill in the [BRACKETS] with your own facts.

Asking at the start

In the quote

To book the work, I take a deposit of [AMOUNT OR PERCENT] when you accept this quote. The rest is due [WHEN]. I start on [DATE], once the deposit has reached me.

After they say yes

Thank you, I would be glad to do this. To confirm your place I need a deposit of [AMOUNT] by [DATE]. Invoice [NUMBER] is attached. I start on [START DATE] once it has reached me.

A short ask

Before I start, I take [PERCENT] up front: [AMOUNT]. The invoice is attached. Thank you.

Explaining it

What it covers

The deposit is [PART OF THE PRICE, TAKEN OFF THE FINAL INVOICE / A BOOKING FEE]. It covers [WHAT, FOR EXAMPLE, THE DATES I HOLD FOR YOU AND THE FIRST STAGE].

Why you ask

I ask for a deposit from every new client. It lets me hold the dates [ADD IF TRUE: AND COVER [COSTS] AT THE START].

Is it refundable?

The deposit is [REFUNDABLE UNTIL [DATE] / NOT REFUNDABLE ONCE I START]. This is also in the quote of [DATE].

A client who pushes back

They would rather pay at the end

I understand. For a new client I need a deposit. For a client I have worked with before I can invoice at the end. [ADD IF TRUE: IF YOU WOULD LIKE TO START WITH A SMALLER DEPOSIT, I CAN DO [AMOUNT].]

A smaller deposit

I can accept [AMOUNT] now and the rest in [NUMBER] stages: [STAGES AND DATES]. Please confirm by [DATE].

A client you have worked with

Since we have worked together before, I will not ask for a deposit this time. Payment is due [NUMBER] days after the invoice.

After you ask

Deposit received

Thank you, the deposit of [AMOUNT] reached me on [DATE]. I will start on [DATE]. The next payment is due [WHEN].

Deposit not yet paid

I have not yet seen the deposit of [AMOUNT] on invoice [NUMBER]. I am holding [DATES] for you until [DATE]. If you want to go ahead, please pay by then, or tell me if you would like to move the dates.

A staged project

The project is paid in [NUMBER] parts: [PERCENT] to start, [PERCENT] at [MILESTONE] and [PERCENT] on delivery. Each part is invoiced when it is due.

<https://proskillpacks.github.io/freelance/how-to-ask-a-client-for-a-deposit/>

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The full version: Scope of Work Builder. Paste the brief for a job you have won. Get a scope of work with numbered deliverables, exclusions, client inputs, milestones and a payment schedule.

\$5, one price. Half price for the first 10 buyers with code FIRST10. 30-day refund.

More about it: <https://proskillpacks.github.io/skills/scope-of-work-builder/>